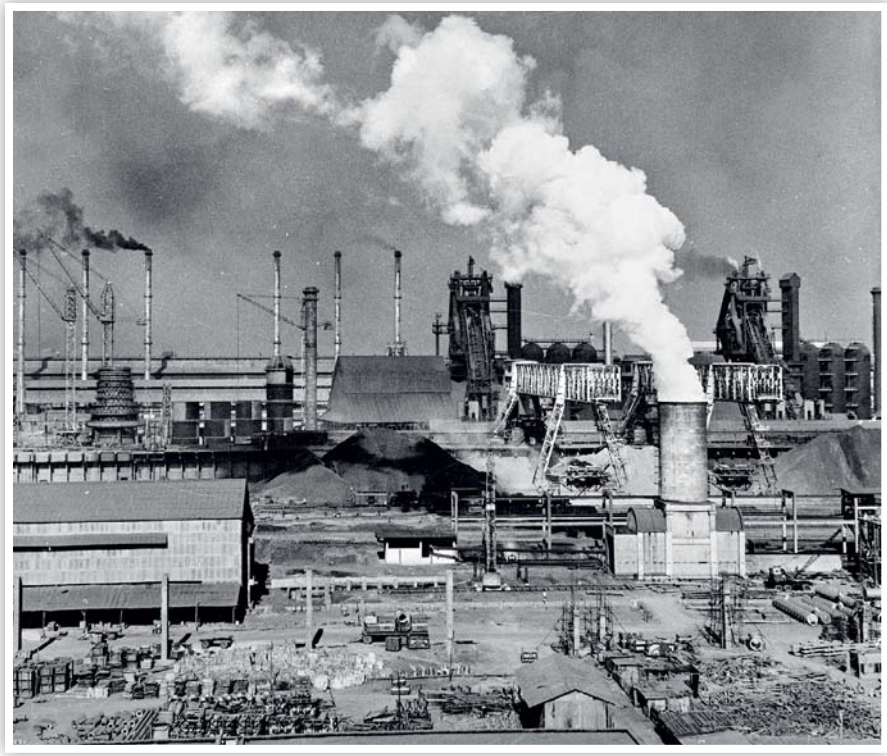






RINGSIDE VIEW (from left) 'Bhilai Steel Works'; 'Untitled'; and (bottom) 'Men on a riffing of a Swedish ship', by Sunil Janah



PHOTOGRAPHY

In the *Making*

AN EXHIBITION OF THE LATE SUNIL JANAH'S PHOTOGRAPHS SHOWS A NEWLY INDEPENDENT INDIA COMING BACK TO LIFE

BY THE TIME HE WAS 30, Sunil Janah (1918-2012) had already done the work for which he would be best remembered. In 1943, as a 25-year-old photography enthusiast, he was sent by Communist leader P.C. Joshi to document the famine ravaging Bengal's rural districts. Janah undertook most of these journeys in partnership with Chittaprosad, a painter and print-maker. Together, Janah and Chitto created an incredible and indelible visual record of mass tragedy and struggle.

Printed in Joshi's Communist newspaper *People's War*, Chittaprosad's drawings and etchings and Janah's stark photographs gave us images of a Bengal caught in the historic pincer between the end of a bloody Empire and the fallout of a global conflict.

By the time Independence came around, Janah had not only photographed the famine but also taken amazing, candid portraits of figures like Nehru, Gandhi and Jinnah. The photos included in the show *Making a Photograph* (on display at Kolkata's Experimenter Gallery till March 26) are 'portraits' of a completely different order. Today, as the Hindutva airbrush industry goes into over-drive trying to wipe out accurate memories of the first years of Independence, these gorgeous photographs (printed by Janah himself) give the lie to the absurd claim that 'nothing was done in the first 70 years of India's independence'.

SUNIL JANAH'S PHOTOGRAPHS GIVE LIE TO THE ABSURD CLAIM THAT NOTHING WAS DONE IN THE FIRST 70 YEARS OF INDEPENDENCE

In these pictures, we see a shattered, eviscerated country energetically beginning to put itself together, attempting courageously to engage with the remaining half of the 20th century. Through these photos of human labour surrounded by engineered metal and furnace